All these anxieties culminated in a stormy meeting of the British commanders on the evening of 8 December. By this time, Elphinstone, Shelton and Macnaghten were barely on speaking terms, and the childishly obstreperous Shelton was especially disparaging about the Envoy. ‘I will sneer at him,’ he announced. ‘I like to sneer at him.’[95] At Councils of War he was openly insolent to the General, rolling himself up in his quilt on the floor, from which requests for his opinion would be answered with loud snores.

At the meeting, Elphinstone produced the written letter Macnaghten had requested, taking formal responsibility for opening surrender negotiations, explaining that:

> after having held our position here for upwards of three weeks in a state of siege, from the want of provisions and forage, the reduced state of our troops, the large number of wounded and sick, the difficulty of defending the extensive and ill-situated cantonment we occupy, the near approach of winter, our communication cut off, no prospect of relief, and the whole country in arms against us, I am of the opinion that it is not feasible any longer to maintain our position in this country, and that you ought to avail yourself of the offer to negotiate which has been made to you.[96]

The other officers also formally declared the British situation untenable, ‘giving it as their decided and unqualified opinion that no more military operations could be undertaken by the troops in their present condition, and that therefore no time should be lost in negotiating for a safe retreat to Hindustan, without any reference to Shah Shuja or his interests, for their first duty was to provide for the honour and welfare of the British troops under their command’.[97] The readiness of the military to abandon Shuja stood in stark contrast to the Shah’s remarkable fidelity to the British, despite a stream of tempting proposals from the rebels for him to abandon his unpopular Kafir allies. Macnaghten repeatedly warned that any attempt to abandon Shuja would cover the British with ‘everlasting infamy’. But he was overruled and ordered to meet with Akbar Khan to see what terms he could get to guarantee the safety of the British during an immediate withdrawal from Afghanistan.

This first meeting between the two took place on the icy banks of the Kabul River, just beyond the charred remains of the bridge. Macnaghten was accompanied by Lawrence, Trevor and Mackenzie; Akbar brought with him all the leading chiefs of the rebellion.[98] Macnaghten began with a characteristically preening and disingenuous preamble, which he read out in